MOOD OF THE NATION POLL

SPORTS

ENDURING SUPREMACY

The icons retain the summit even as youngsters break through

By **SUHANI SINGH**



1 VIRAT KOHLI
43 [44.1]

Virat Kohli may now be active in just one format for the Men in Blue, but his supremacy in cricket shows no sign of waning. His recent ODI knocks reaffirm that the 37-year-old remains India's finest batter—and one who, if fitness and motivation hold, could yet surpass Sachin Tendulkar as the game's most prolific run-scorer. Second to him is M.S. Dhoni, who—years after stepping away from international cricket—continues to command the public imagination, sustained by his annual two-month return in the Indian Premier League.

The latest Mood of the Nation (MOTN) poll for India's best male cricketer suggests that the upcoming ICC Men's T20 World Cup is top of mind, with three members of the squad featuring on the list: former captain Hardik Pandya, current skipper Suryakumar Yadav, and the explosive young opener Abhishek Sharma, who makes his MOTN debut at No. 6. The Test and ODI captain, Shubman Gill, however, slides down the rankings to No. 7 after a prolonged dip in form.

It comes as no surprise that members of the newly crowned women's ODI world champion side shine the brightest. Smriti Mandhana, the elegant left-hander and the team's most reliable run-getter, retains top spot despite a notable percentage drop since the August 2025 poll. The biggest mover—at the expense of the squad's captain and middle-order fulcrum Harmanpreet Kaur no less—is



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1 NEERAJ CHOPRA *(Athletics)*
20.9 [33.9]

Q. Who is India's No. 1 male sportsperson?



2 SUNIL CHHETRI *(Football)*
17.1 [13.6]



3 D. GUKESH *(Chess)*
16.2 [8.9]



4 MANPREET SINGH *(Hockey)*
14.7 [1.2]



5 HARMANPREET SINGH *(Hockey)*
4.5 [0.8]